12-13
Long but smooth. Read almost an entire book "The Tipping Point". What a feeling to be met with a sign Mr. & Mrs. Zohar. Royal Palm ***** and I mean everything.
14
Zanzibar. As it turned out – not Boat People although going there was o.k. 2 guides a chauffer and a mini van. Stone Town – unique,Moslem, peaceful, beautiful vistas, narrow streets, time stands still. Spice tour - great experience. Exciting, educational, touch, feel and taste. Long drive to Breezes but well worth it. Look at the room the surroundings the Colonials are coming!
15
What a breeze by contrast to yesterday – just relax by the beach. Sea sick and vomit like a madman on the return leg - great! Dinner on the beach at Sea Cliff to recover.
16
Rovos Rail the most luxurious train in the world. Owned by Rohan Vos who is a staff member with wife and his daughter. Formal dining. The works. HWAGE our suite – perfect.
17
Watching people. Mostly Canadian. What a routine: wake-up, wash-up-breakfast – read lecture- lunch-snooze-lounge and drinks- read some more- not much talking-dinner-bed.

19

Great excursion to the falls. Colonial roughing it with an open bar B-B-Q of lobster and lamb chops and waiters after a tiring but nothing like Machu Pichu . No wonder the native Africans are after the whites. Good to be out for a change it can get a bit cagey.

It's after dinner and it's now official – mom is losing it! This is an original (mom not Yogi Bera) "Too much of not much is too much!" We brace ourselves for the Zambian shake.

20

Trains are especially conducive to sex. Even if the experience is average the parties swear that the earth moved. Trains are also good for lazy sex. You go through the motions and the train does the rest.

We are grossly underdressed for the occasion. Especially mom. You should see some of the outfits. And men in white and black tuxedos (admittedly not everybody but 90% of the men have proper WASP (suits) attires. Decadent is a good word to describe the experience. People in black ties with a glass of champagne and brie in their hands discussing the plight of the African people.

Broke the ice on meeting people. Nice Ausies, South Africans. Lots of Canadians wasps. We don't like them at home – we don't like them abroad.

Being totally insulated from the world for 5 days – is a first. Mom is a bit antsy but settled down somewhat today. Interesting business model: over-the-top, manage expectations, hands-on owner/busboy oh so close to the customer.

The lectures are great – 2 a day when on the train. Wish there was more discussion or interaction. Concluded it is not in the business model. When you have 60 odd people on one train you do not take the risk of doing anything that all 60 may not agree. Movie,

music, open political discussions etc., We can all agree on drink, eat, sleep and the rest. Everything is on the house. Makes you feel oh so special.

21

That was a night from hell. All sex jokes aside when the train rock n' roll's like it did all night it's no joke. But today is a new day. You see a fall you see them all – not quite. Awesome first impression of VF. We are in colonial Africa now with all its trimmings at the VF hotel one of the top 100 in the world and absolutely breathtakingly unique. Only the pictures can describe. Afternoon sunset cruise on the Zambezi – decadent. Even the African dancing show was a first class (albeit a touristy) event.

Finally connected with the boys. They are on fire. Who needs me? Finally watched TV after 6 days. The world is still ugly. We have gone back a century here at the VF hotel. It may not have been right, it may not have been nice but it sure as hell was fun while it lasted.

22

Tour of the Falls. Kol-Pina-Pnina. You cannot stop shooting picture for fear that you may not remember this great place or beautiful scene. Off to a helicopter ride. Mom has never been so content and relaxed. Me, I've been like this as soon as we left. Banf is an old memory – never again. Reversal of fortunes. Mom fell ill during the Helicopter ride, I thought it was spectacular. The pictures are the evidence. A $140 USD refund for mom to be mailed on a back of an elephant. It's only money. Back on the train. Oh boy another gourmet dinner with plenty of wine.

23

O.K. you win – we cannot go on eating and drinking like this. Let the Goyim go to dinner. We skip. Day on the train 2 great lectures on South African history & politics and on the tycoon & visionary Cecil Rhodes (scholarships). Success ingredients: non-conformist, visionary yet pragmatic and practical, attention to details, romantic, likes people, people like him. Befriend your enemies. Lunch was so awesome that we have to skip dinner. Executive decisions for today: Rose wine over champagne, will have desert and skip the cheese plate, espresso rather than coffee, screw it lets have breakfast in the second dining room and the big one: which pictures to delete before I run out of hard disk space. Finished my third (!) book and I am 100 pages or so into the fourth. Mom is also reading like a junkie. We leave Zimbabwe tonight and cross to South Africa. Tomorrow is game day. We stay at a private 5 star game lodge. What a life.

24

Can this trip get any better? Today at Kapama (Private Game Reserve). This is not roughing it. Look at the pictures. We stay in a "hut". The grounds are spectacular. The Game Drive – chaval al hazman. The animals, the sunset, the views, the night trip. And wouldn't you know a sunset break with an open bar. Dinner around the "camp fire". Good conversation with the Ausies and the South Africans. Cannot decide which pictures to drop from the roster. Intel's and Ofoto stock rising. Tried to get the kids and Bath _ Sheva for her birthday but the phones are constantly busy.

25

Can it get better than that? It bloody hell can. Today was the single most exciting day of the trip so far, but frankly I cannot see how it can be outdone. We got up at 6 and went out to a Game drive at 6:30 A.M. Not only did we see all the animals from close range

breakfast on an Impala and after finishing breakfast cleaned (licked) its face, cleared (dragged the Impala by its teeth) the table, Put the food in the refrigerators (covered it with branches and leaves) and went to look for its cub and call her for breakfast. We were told that this scene is extremely rare in game watching. In fact the owner of Rovos did not get to see a Leopard in her 15 years of Game Safaris. In fact we were told that the video clip I took could have commercial value, but who cares? On top of this only mom and myself of the entire group got to see this scene in its entirety. The SA couple and the Ausie couple decided to skip the morning drive. And oh boy regretted it. So mom and I the Ranger and the Tracker were the only one in the vehicle. You must see the video and the sequence of the stills.

The afternoon was spent on more game watching and at the Cheetah breeding reserve. The pictures will tell the rest. We have wonderful enamel cups (mugs) for all 6 and a 7th one for any volunteers. Stocked up on T-Shirts. The stores love us: What size? All from 0-6, how many? 6. We are now crashed at our cabin. You should see the red carpet and champagne reception (with Herman playing the Accordion – too much). Our next if not only decision tonight is whether or not we dress up (tie and jacket) and go for dinner or skip it like the last night on the train. We'll tell you tomorrow.

26

Pretoria- a come down day. Basically a non-event but a good change of pace. The Rovos Rail tour was something else. Champagne, violins, ambiance unbelievable. Pride of ownership. A personal tour , history and personal story by Rohan. You have to be that passionate to run a railway the way he does. The little "over-the-top" things are there to make you feel special to make you feel important, to make you overlook other things that may and in Africa will go wrong with the logistics of transporting 60 people over 6500 kilometers through the most spectacular scenery imaginable. Last night we did not but tonight we are thinking of going to dinner, eventhough we had an excellent juicy steak for lunch.

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27

It could get surprisingly cold in South Africa. Today we toured Kimberly the diamond capital of SA. Nice, quaint back for lunch on the train. Beautiful afternoon on the train enough said. Tonight at dinner we were reflecting on this highly unique experience. In particular the subtle yet so unique aspects of the client care and customer service culture that is in a class by itself. To sustain this level of excellence for 13 days must be a culture rather than excellent performance. Things that impressed the hell out of us:

- Every staff member does what is required whether or not it is their job
- The staff knows what wine you ordered and refill your glass whether or not it is the waiter who took your order.
- Dishes are removed at once when all (or both) parties are finished
- Staff anticipates your needs and wants and treat you personally by name as if you were the only guest on the train
- Managing expectations to create customer delight
- Doing the small yet so considerate things (little gifts, wash clothes and drinks on return to train, album, flower changes, lapel flowers etc.,
- No limits on anything, food , drinks etc., which is the customer experience but not a major operating cost. Creates the impression of exceptional value for money.
- Engage clients in conversation, advice, assistance etc.,

In studying this unique model one can learn a hell of a lot about how to run a business. We could easily write this trip down as a business expense. Last night on the train a spontaneous party on the observation deck. On a scale of 10 – 10.

28

Look up Quaint in the dictionary and you'll get a picture of MisJuisFonten. Another one man's dream just because he wants to. Our last meal on the train. As if knowing that we will never encounter a similar experience – we gorged. The food was equisite and between the two of us we drank better than a bottle of our new favorite – Rose. A mixed feeling sets in as we approach Cape Town. On the one hand sad that this dream journey is over. Sad to part with the cabin the train the staff and some of the passengers knowing that despite all the "stay in touches" they will fade into memory. On the other hand exhilarated and delighted by the experience and looking forward to exploring Cape Town and yes, come home. Spoke to Sharon at length and to Bath Sheva. We are back in the 21st with TV – 5 star HI and CNN. Our first encounter with the room and the service at the restaurant reminds us that the colonial era is over.

29

The dream continues. Today we went to the wine land north of CapeTown. It has got to be the most beautiful all around scenery that we have seen anywhere. Even mom could not stop clicking the camera away. We had three separate wine testing and the first two at least were heavenly. Only the four of us (a couple of Australians) The restaurant for lunch – just look at the pictures. Tonight we went to a restaurant of our choice on our account – the first time on this trip! Blues at Camps Bay – great food on the ocean front but as the guide said a bit overrated. To modern for Colonials. On the way back from the tour we went through the water front and harbor and we are going to see more tomorrow. But quick judgment: It must be the most beautiful city in the world. Anyway we must find away to stop this orgy of eating and drinking. One more night and we are headed home. Perfect timing.